Graphic Design

Advance Digital Illustration

Summary Notes

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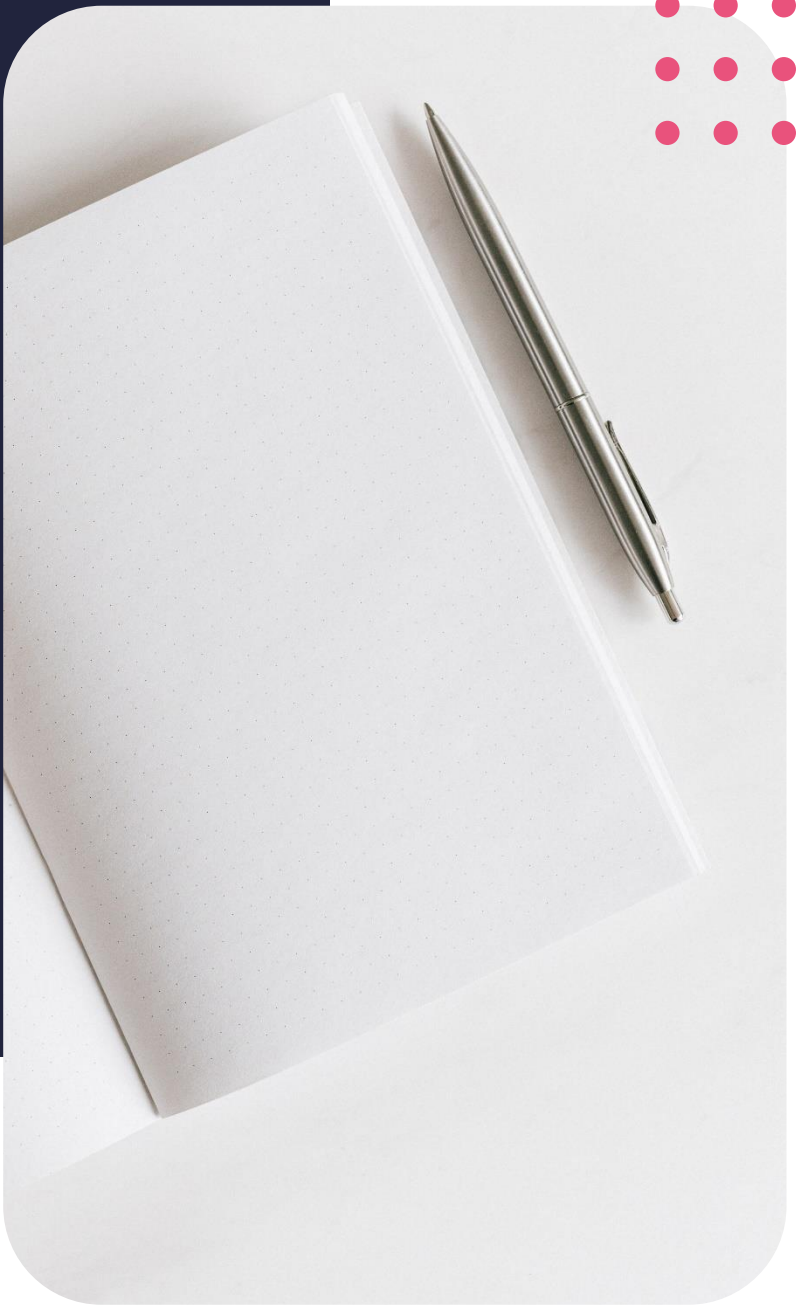


What is digital illustration?

The first step is understanding what digital illustration is. Digital illustration, also known as computer illustration, is the use of digital tools to create images through the imagination of the artist, usually through a device such as a drawing tablet or a mouse.

The origin of digital illustration

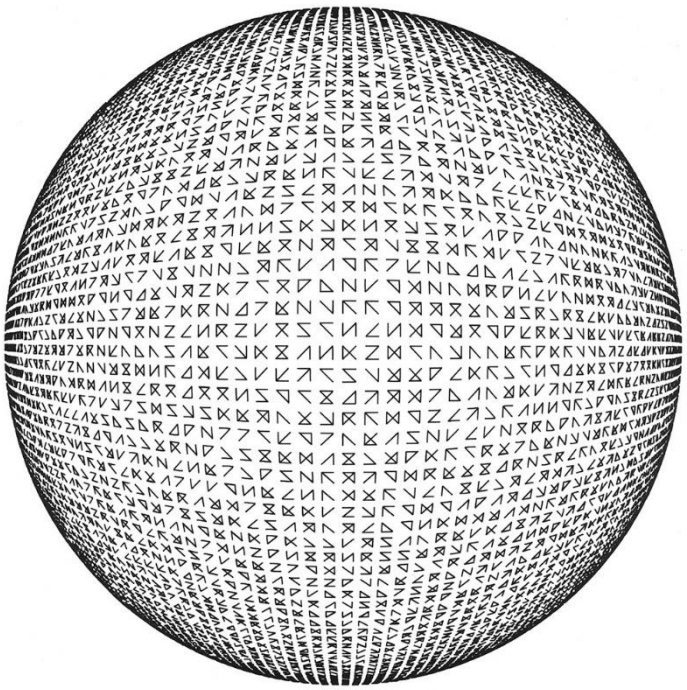
In the 1960s computers were still new, and gaining access to them was very difficult. Computers back then was heavy and bulky, these machines were too expensive for the average person. You would find computers almost the size of a room in laboratories, universities and large corporations, as they were only ones who could afford these machines.

This meant the pioneers would program the computers. To add to this there was no 'user interface', things like a mouse, desktop icons and design software did not exist. A handful of artists and computer scientists had the freedom By to explore the computers full creative potential.

Using the alphabet, sides of a square and diagnols and created an alphabet which lead to the phase "cubic limit"

In the 1980s digital illustration took the world by storm and a whole new meaning with the creative tools such as Adobe software, Corel Draw and Paint were launched (I know right)!

Users are only limited by their imagination.



P-128, sphereless, pen plotter drawing on paper, 1972 Alphabet: a square and its 2 diagonals

'The Shere' created in 1972.

The types of digital illustration

A Digital Illustrator's job is to create original artwork, usually for video games, magazine editorials, web comics, infographics, character design, animation, and film, as well as more recently television series.

Careers

As a digital illustrator you have many career options. You have many options, working for a studio, freelance, workfrom home, contract work. These are some of the amazing field you can work in:

Film and TV: A film studio may ask you to create the concept art for battle of a hero fighting a villain.

Video Games: Designing tiles, sprites, character design and level designs.

Publishing: Childrens Books, Book Covers, Graphic Novels may be commission by a publisher.

Comicbook and Comic Strip artists: You may be commissioned to create a daily comic strip for a newspaper. You may work

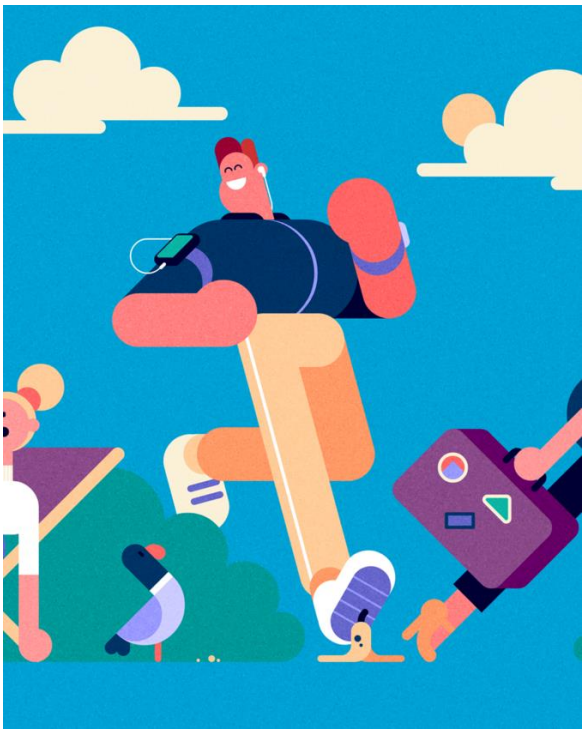
on a graphic novel for a Comicbook Studio.

Types of digital illustration

The types of illustration that are quite popular at the moment include: Flat illustration, Pixel art, 2D illustration, 3D illustration and Stylised illustration.

Flat illustration

Flat illustration, also known as vector art, is art created in vector format. As you are familiar with the term vector, it should make sense that this type of artwork is created in a vector editing software. Who can tell me which Adobe application is a vector editing software? Yes, Illustrator is a vector editing software.



Artwork by Robin Davey

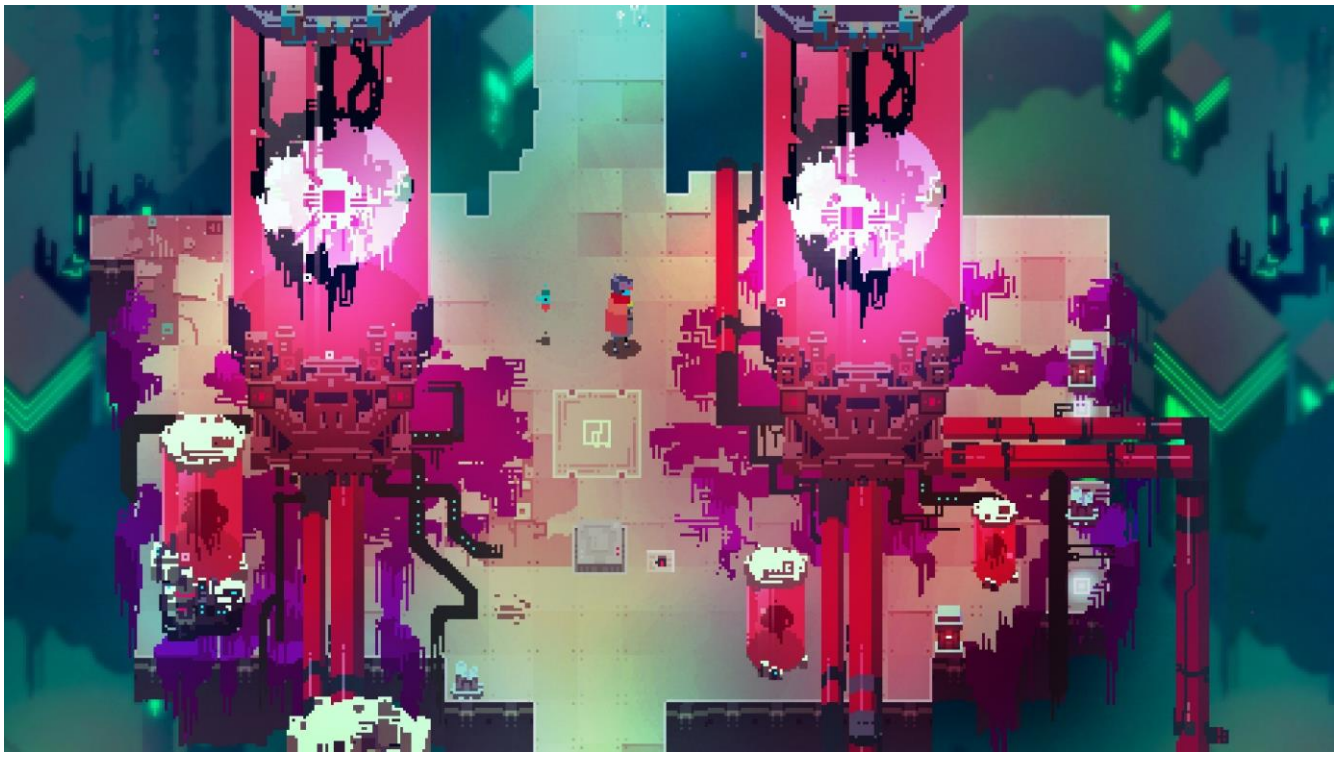
Pixel art

Like the name implies, consists of pixels and is a form of raster or bitmap-based illustration. It is created using software like Photoshop, GIMP and Aseprite. The look and feel of 8-bit, 16-bit and 32-Bit was created to illustrate or code graphics for computers games, video game and arcade games.

In pixel art, the colour palette is usually limited to a certain size, (120x120 pixels for example). Sometimes the pixel art colour palette can be only two colours.

These limitations forced game and level designers to come up with new and innovative ways to create games with limited data available. For example, a moustache was added to Mario to make him feel more 'Human'.

Pixel art gave birth to a whole generation arcade and video consoles. Starting with a game call pong. These games opened the doors for games like Fifa, Fortnite and Dota2.



Video game: Hyper Light Drifter

2D illustration

A 2D Illustrator or animator creates 2-dimensional art. They also create flat characters and backgrounds.The images created in 2D can be used for technical drawings, cartoons, video game design, web animation, clothing design and avatar. This type of Illustration is used to create most tv, web, adult cartoons and 2D character design we see today. These types of illustration usually have outlines to define their details. Sometimes can also have a flat vector feel.

This illustration can also be known as traditional illustration, we use this name because in the early days all these illustrations were sketched, inked, and coloured by hand. Disney has made this style famous with all their classic 2D movies. Like Beauty and the beast, Bambi, The Little Mermaid.

It’s an indescribable feeling when you give your character part of your own personality.
These 2d illustrations today can be created in Adobe Illustrator and then animated in Adobe After Effects.

Artwork by Mike Mac

3D illustration

3D has become a very interesting way for designers and illustrators to create designs with depth. is a very convenient way These 3d designs filter into typography, illustration, avatars, product design and web design.

3D illustration is commonly used in 3D animation like Finding Nemo and in video games such as Fortnite. 3D illustration is created in software like Blender, 3D Studio Max, Maya and MagicaVoxel.(for Unity to create games). A whole industry has emerged in the past few years that heavily depends on the use of 3D somewhere in the pipeline.

How is 3D a part or filtering into graphic design. This is used in interactive apps. 3D animation is more frequently used for commercials and magazine editorials. Designers can benefit by creating 3D icons and characters. 3D illustration in design and illustration can serve as a boost in your design toolkit and looks great on your resume.

Artwork by Yum Yum

Stylised illustration

If something is stylised it means it's represented in a non-naturalistic conventional form. The heart-shaped symbol in the popular phrase The tshirt with I heart New York is a perfect example of stylizarion.

Anything can be *stylised* — an entire movie or play or wardrobe, for example. Lots of stylization happens in the concept art for movie in the form of backgrounds and characters. This quote from director Elia Kazan explain stylizing really well: "*Stylized* acting and direction is to realistic acting and direction as poetry is to prose." From the Old English word *stile* meaning "designation, title, manner or mode of expression."

Artwork by Yan Liang

Illustration tips

You can make use of these tips using many illustration applications, from Aseprite and Blender to the more powerful Adobe package.

1. **Form or Shape**
   The first tip I would like to share is give your illustration or character the form or shape that is interesting to look at, for example if you just had the silhouette of the character would it stand out?

2. **Use your canvas openly**
   Do not be scared to show a simple or even flat colour background with a complex illustration. Every element does not have to be over detailed. A detailed character on a simple background can jump off the canvas.

3. **Limit your colours**
   When setting up your colours for any illustration start of with 2-4 base colours and work from there. Complementary colours work very well with this approach.

4. **Work to scale**
   Even with vector which can be scaled without losing quality, it is important to have the right size of artwork before you begin. This is crucial from web and print. Make sure your client, boss give you a clear indication of scale.

5. **Be original**
   Take inspiration from other artists, borrow techniques. You should create a unique style for your illustrations, harder than it sounds? Bring in elements are yourself and nostalgia, no one can be you as well as YOU!

Conclusion

Recapping on what we've learned today; we looked at what digital illustration is and its origins. We then moved over to a brief introduction to the Types of Digital Illustration and looked at how to practically apply these elements. We managed to cover the top 5 types of illustration and their contents.

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